

Vertigo

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No 826 April 2019



NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Wellington Section Monthly Bulletin

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WORLD TOUR
BANFF CENTRE
MOUNTAIN FILM FESTIVAL
Click to make a booking

About to set off from a bivvy on Aokaparangi for Maungahuka Hut
- in the middle distance along the sunlit ridge [More here](#)

Chair's Report

April 2019

Do you really know if what you are doing is working? Probably not. Not unless its something like boiling water or starting your car. It seems reasonable to assume that putting a key into the ignition and turning it caused the car to start. Equally, not putting a key into the ignition caused the car not to start. In more complex situations where the number of variables is greater, such as alpine climbing, it's harder to know what causes what. You might successfully top out on a summit but was that because of good planning, preparation and capability or was it just that nothing happened to go wrong and the weather held. If the weather holds and conditions are good your margin for error is much wider and bad planning or errors of judgment have no impact and go unnoticed. Also, making dumb decisions in a forgiving environment is likely to reinforce your perception that you are making good decisions. This is a type of survivor bias or confirmation bias. It can look like arrogance to the untrained eye. The more you 'get away with it' the more you're likely to believe you made the right decisions. Perhaps you did. Until you don't get away with it. This doesn't apply to climbing alone. It applies to anything you do. In the risk-taking world of alpine climbing it is more acute and the consequences more stark. On the other hand, if there was no risk, you might as well play golf.

Unfortunately, I can't find any reliable stats on the death rate from golf other than the fact that it happens and mostly to people over sixty. I hear you say 'ah well it isn't the golf then' but the stats I did find include being hit by a golf ball, so not heart attacks or strokes alone. Maybe people over 60 are just worse at golf.

What I also found is that mountaineering has a 1 in 1,750 chance of dying, while playing table games has a 1 in 100 million chance of dying – possibly when your opponent shoves the scrabble letters down your throat and strangles you. There seems to be a popular assumption that it is better to die doing something you enjoy as opposed to something you don't - like golf. I'm not sure it makes much difference once you're dead, but I don't think I'll take up golf because it's less likely to kill me. I'd rather go climbing and focus on managing the risk so that I can live long enough to be a bad golfer. Or worse, a bad financial advisor – now there's an applied example of not knowing if what you're doing actually works - but that will have to wait for next months Vertigo.

Finally:

"Perhaps our greatest distinction as a species is our capacity, unique among animals, to make counter-evolutionary choices."— Jared Diamond

Cheers
Simon



Simon Williamson
Chair: NZAC Wellington

From the Editor

Just the usual this month - send in your trip reports! You're only getting a Tararua item this month because that's all I've been able to get to. Let's have some proper climbing trip reports please. It's trip reports that are valued most by Vertigo readers. So, just type up a report of between half and three pages as a Word Doc, email it to occasionalclimber@gmail.com with up to six jpeg images (with captions) if you have them and I'll (happily) format it for Vertigo.

Peter

Section News

All Section night talks are held at The Third Eye, Tuatara Brewery, level 2, 30 Arthur Street, from 6pm. With prior arrangement, also a good place to collect or return hired climbing gear. If you would like to make a presentation at a future Section night, or have a suggestion about someone else to present, please let Peter know - occasionalclimber@gmail.com. The 22 October and 19 November spots remain open at time of writing.

May Section night

Tues 21st May, Peter Laurenson will give a 'how to' presentation about how to take your photography in the hills to a higher level. Check it out before you prepare for this year's photocomp.

Section nights beyond April

Tues 18th Jun, Penny Webster will take us through her recent climb of Mt Everest.

Tues 23rd Jul, Nina Sawicki will present her recent trekking in Peru.

Tues 20th Aug, Peter Ambrose and Guy Dubuis will take us through their judging of the Wellington Section 2019 photo competition.

Tues 17th Sep, Jo Morgan will share some of her recent experiences climbing in our biggest mountains.

Tues 22nd Oct and 19th nov, TBC ...

Letters

Ahhh no!

No-one took Brian Wilkins' lead and sent in another letter.

Come on people - there must a few golfers out there who now want to hang, draw and quarter Simon. But that's illegal. You can always demonstrate how that pen is so much mightier than a sword though

More dangerous than scrabble?
Scrabble players don't have a rope >>>
Photo Derek Cheng - Stefan Gerl looks longingly at his next quickdraw as he uses a toe-hook to engage with the upper demands of Taipan Wall. Cardigan Street (28), Taipan Wall, Grampians, Australia



Section News

Gear Hire

The Section has gear for hire: avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes, PLBs, ice hammers (entry level). Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on return.

To hire gear please fill in the form [here](#). You can find out more from [Genevieve](#).

Some advance notice, especially over the Christmas period, is appreciated as gear is in higher demand and often needs to be retrieved from the gear store. To collect or return your gear liaise with Genevieve.

Accommodation on Mt Ruapehu

Our snowcraft courses for the past few years have been run out of the Manawatu Tramping and Skiing Club lodge on Whakapapa. We're always made to feel welcome and the lodge is well situated a short walk from the top of the Bruce Road. Membership to the club is extremely reasonable - \$35 per year or \$50 for a family membership. Members stay at the lodge for \$36 a night including food. If you're looking for somewhere to base yourself for your winter pursuits or rock-climbing over the summer months go to www.mtsc.org.nz/joining.php to find out more about joining the club.



Safety on the Tongariro Alpine Crossing

In early March MSC facilitated the first meeting of a new expert advisory panel. The diverse group was specifically brought together to look at solutions for reducing safety incidents on New Zealand's most popular day tramp, the Tongariro Alpine Crossing (TAC). More [here](#).

Notices

NZAC instruction courses

Click for more details [Ice Climbing](#) [Ski Touring](#) (and the new guide [here](#)) [High Alpine Skills](#)

New 6th Edition 2018 – Aspiring Guides Technical Mountaineering

An excellent learning resource and a handy reference for experienced alpinists. This manual can be purchased online [here](#). Log in first for your member discount.

NZAC Veteran's Meet 1990 – Arthur's Pass

In 1990 the New Zealand Alpine Club held a Veteran members meet at the Club's Arthur's Pass Lodge. This was a chance for a get-together and hike in the local area, including one to Lake Kaurapataka, followed by a dinner and speeches featuring the then Club President Geoff Gabites. More [here](#).

NZ Alpine Journals digitised

Journals from 1892 until 2014 are all now available to view digitally. Readers have two options: you can search across all volumes using 'Search', and you can access single volumes via the 'Content' menu. Access by volume has an extended user interface where you can also view (and copy) the transcript. More [here](#).



A Tomtit on Staveley Hill, Mount Somers
Photo Peter Laurenson

Coming Trips, Courses, Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs for Wellington Section members are covered by the Section.

If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or to find out more, email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the Committee can help with advertising and logistics.

When	What and where
Thursday 6th and 13th June	Banff Mountain Film Festival 2019 This year's screenings will be at the Embassy Theatre. A Blue programme and Red programme. Click the links to make your booking >>>
29th-30th June	NZAC weekend training for beginner instructors Interested volunteer instructors who are members should complete the NZAC Volunteer Instructor/Trip Leader registration form here .
26th-28th July 2nd-4th August 16th-18th August 23rd-25th August 6th-8th September	Snowcraft 2019 Beginner course - Whakapapa Beginner course - Whakapapa Intermediate/Advanced course - Whakapapa Intermediate/Advanced course - Whakapapa Post-course trip - Tukino To find out more contact Nish - catchnishie@gmail.com Click to book your spot.



Contemplating Kangtega (6,779m - left of centre) and Tamserku (6,608m - centre), Khumbu, Nepal, Dec 2017
Photo Will Laurenson

banffmountainfestival.ca

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MOUNTAIN
FILM FESTIVAL
WORLD TOUR

Book Blue Programme 6 June

Book Red Programme 13 June

Wellington

June 6 & 13 2019

www.banff.nz

 NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Trip Reports

A trip beyond memory lane

Mount Holdsworth > Aokaparangi > Maungahuka > Cone Ridge

Words and pictures Peter Laurenson

I almost felt teary. Waves of nostalgia and vivid memories of little five year-old sons and my staffy Polly came flooding back as I trudged up the Gentle Annie Track. I felt like a passing observer going by Lookout Rock – the memories of my middle son Ed scurrying all over it were so clear. But that was more than a decade ago now. Ed is now at Otago Uni and Will into his Year 12 at Wellington College. Polly died over five years ago, though I still think of her most days.

The trail up to Powell Hut and on to Mount Holdsworth is an ideal introduction to the Tararuas for youngsters – an easy way to get up on to the tops. There was a period, when my boys were younger, that I came this way fairly frequently. After a ten year hiatus though, I now saw how things had changed since this route has become part of the itinerary of international visitors. A graded footpath with civilised stair cases stretched right up to the junction where you can turn off in the direction of Totara Flats. The fun rocky section below Powell Hut has been overlaid with a significant section of stairs and, upon reaching the top of these, I was confronted with a 'Powell Hut is closed for reconstruction. Do not enter' DOC sign. A flash new 32 bunker is coming soon.

But no matter, my plan didn't involve Powell Hut this time. I wanted to tread some new ground west of Holdsworth, plunging from Holdsworth's trig at 1,470m (pictured here), down a vertical kilometre to Mid Waiohine Hut at 380m. After a brew at the hut, cross Waiohine River and scramble all the way back up to 1,354m on the top of Aokaparangi, on the main spine of the Tararuas.

The weather forecast was optimistic, although by the time I reached the top of Holdsworth, there were big billowing clouds all around. My knees aren't much of a fan of steep descents, so when the trail dropped 200 metres, only to then climb again to Isobell at 1,385m, I was muttering things to myself like 'here we go, typical Tararuas'. This became a regular thing over the next two days.



The dawn view to Maungahuka Hut from Aokaparangi



On top of Aokaparangi at sunset



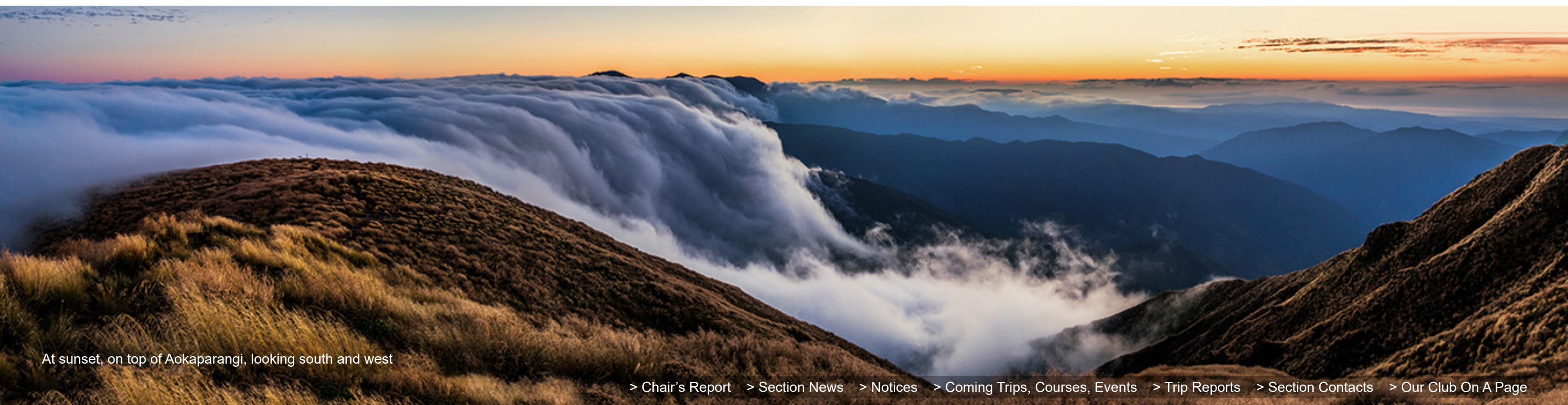
The dawn view to Carkeek Ridge (right) from Aokaparangi

Since departing the Holdsworth carpark it took me ten hours to reach my bivvy spot just a tad east of Aokaparangi's summit that evening. Most of the way had been in bush and it was humid. I had sweated profusely and constantly most of the time and some very unwanted chaffing, in various unpleasant spots, had become increasingly apparent. At least it was good to be free of the closeness of the bush for a while. On top though, I was engulfed in cloud and, with no tarns in sight, I had to use my water sparingly, knowing that Maungahuka Hut was still two or three hours walk away to the south. But with a good forecast, the main point of my trip was to be on the tops for dawn.

Just as the light began to fade and I'd given up any hope of getting some sunset action, a clearing in the clag appeared. I grabbed my camera and quickly got onto the top of Aokaparangi. To the southwest a spectacular cloud formation had draped itself over the low point in the main range north of Maungahuka, hanging in space like a gigantic levitating waterfall. The view north was nearly as good, with huge suspended cloud-falls pouring over the top of Mount Crawford. And above it all was a full moon, peaking from behind mottled mauve cloud. My day's toils had been rewarded.

The night passed slowly as the clouds ebbed and flowed. Often a double halo surrounded the full moon, tempting me to climb out of my bivvy bag to take photos – well, almost. No trouble getting up for the dawn though. It was clear as a bell, with beautiful, delicately textured cloud driven down into the valleys by the cold of the night. The dawn unfolds slowly in autumn, so I enjoyed the ultimate landscape photographer's scenario for a couple of hours.

From the top of Aokaparangi it looked little more than an hour along the ridge to Maungahuka Hut, which gleamed at me in the early morning sunlight. The clear air was deceptive, as was my memory of this stretch of tops. It took about 500 metres of ups and downs, on sometimes quite exposed terrain, to reach the hut two and a half hours after setting off. By the time I reached it the clouds had billowed back up out of the valleys. I took a breather at the hut, knowing that over 1,000 metres of descent to Neill Forks Hut awaited me, to be followed by 650 metres climbing back onto Cone Ridge, then another descent of 700 metres to Totara Flats Hut, virtually all in steep bush. This section was new ground for me so I was interested to see what unfolded.



At sunset, on top of Aokaparangi, looking south and west



Entering goblin forest on the west side of Concertina Knob (1,106m)

With tape applied optimistically to various chaffed areas I set off. On top of Maungahuka there was a clearing in the cloud cover and I got a glimpse of the ridge, dropping 300 metres before ascending again to Concertina Knob. Beyond the knob a plummet through goblin forest into beech awaited, ending at Neill Forks (350m). Looking intently back at me, about 200 metres below on the ridge side, were three deer. The cloud swirled and they were gone. The same thing was happening to Tunui and Tuiti to my right. The swirling clouds made the Tararua Peaks look particularly ominous.

As I descended below 1,100 metres I came free of cloud and, through windows in the dense goblin forest, I enjoyed some nice vistas of the main range between Maungahuka and Aokaparangi to the north, then later of Cone Ridge, Neill and Winchcombe. Eventually the steep descent ended at a swing bridge crossing the Hector River. Immediately on the far side was Neill Forks Hut (350m).



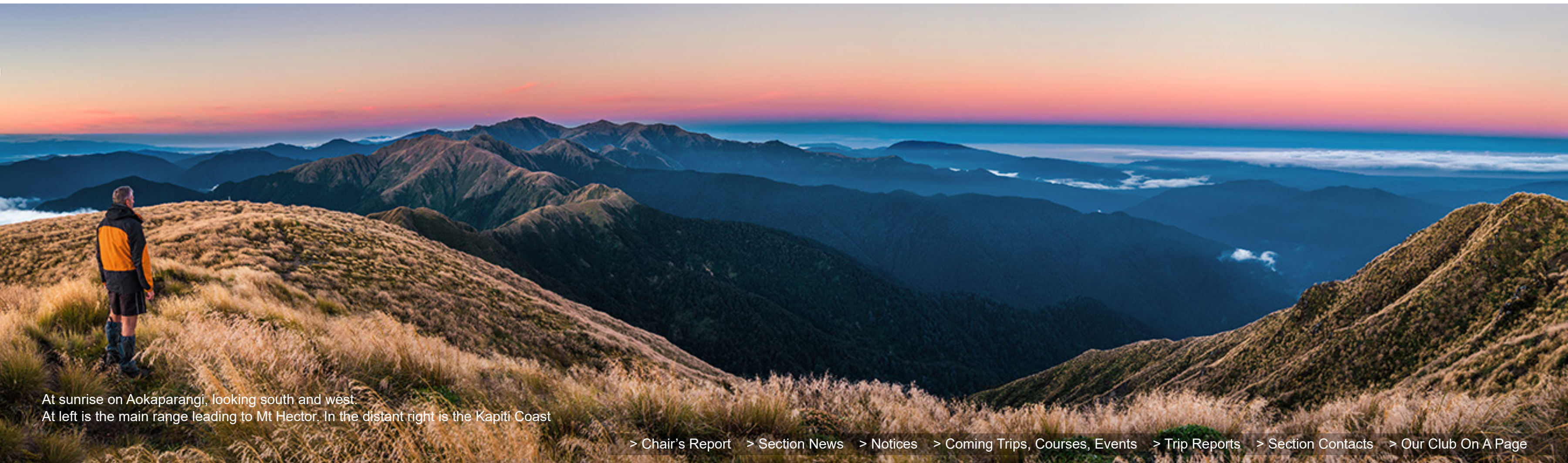
Looking southwest from the swing bridge beside Neill Forks Hut, to Neill Creek (left) and Hector River (right)

I would have liked to spend some time at Neill Forks Hut. Where Hector River is joined by Neill Creek is some lovely scenery. But it was already 4pm and I still had to get over Cone Ridge before dark. Another 650m climb and 700m descent later I trudged in to a deserted Totara Flats Hut, just on nightfall.

Next morning two previous ten hour days had me feeling old as I ambled, in light rain, along the Totara Creek Track in the direction of Gentle Annie. Making me feel even older was the thought that some Tararua hardmen have done what was taking me about 25 hours of walking in just 13 hours! Still, it was good to have added some new memories to my Tararua experiences.

Note to self - get some merino undies ...

For more captioned images and a route map www.occasionalclimber.co.nz



At sunrise on Aokaparangi, looking south and west.
At left is the main range leading to Mt Hector. In the distant right is the Kapiti Coast

Section Contacts

Powered by volunteers

We're always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. A lot goes on to keep our club going, virtually all powered by volunteers. On the back page is our "Club on a page" summary. It gives an at a glance description of all the things we do, how and why. Feel free to print a copy and pass it on to anyone who might be interested in becoming a member or volunteer. And if you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Role	Name	Contact
Chair person	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Treasurer	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Secretary	Stacey Wong	staceycolleena@gmail.com
Gear custodian	Genevieve Luketina	gluketina@hotmail.com
Trip co-ordinator	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Section nights, Vertigo	Peter Laurenson	021 446 725
Social media	Marie Kelly	marieitz4u@gmail.com
Club liaison	Keith Munro	keithm@mtgelab.co.nz
General Committee, Photo comp	Guy Dubuis	guy.dubuis@gmail.com
General Committee	Alexis Belton	belton.alexis@gmail.com
General Committee	Rosie Percival	calicoanne@gmail.com
General Committee	Naomi Seow	naomiseow@gmail.com
General Committee	Derek Cheng	derekcheng.nz@gmail.com
General Committee	Scott Harper	scott.harper@hotmail.co.nz
Patron	John Nankervis	
Rock drill overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 555 5893



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Time to change?
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Keith Munro KiwiSaver and Mortgage Adviser 027 654 6568 keithm@mtgelab.co.nz

*SRI may specifically exclude investments in:
• Alcohol production • Gambling operations • Tobacco production, distribution, supply & retailing • Military weapons manufacturing • Civilian firearms production, distribution, supply & retailing • Nuclear power production & uranium mining • Fossil fuels exploration, extraction, refinement, distribution, supply & retailing • Adult entertainment content production • Genetically modified organisms, excluding research & Development



WHAT WE DO

FOR MEMBERS

Facilities

- * Huts
- * Gear
- * Library
- * Discounts

Training

- * Level 1- 3 winter skills
- * Summer rock
- * Instructors

Climbing trips

- * Section
- * National
- * International

FOR MEMBERS AND WIDER PUBLIC

Publications

- * Website
- * Social media
- * Vertigo
- * Guide books

Events

- * Banff mountain film festival
- * Reel Rock
- * Photo comp

Networking

- * Section nights
- * Conferences and meetings
- * Lobbying

HOW WE DO IT

Organise, encourage, support, enable

Inform, entertain, promote

OUR RESOURCES

Volunteer time and capabilities, income from events and gear hire, national office support, sponsorship

WHY WE DO IT

Connecting & developing more climbing & mountaineering people, knowledge, skills & experience, thereby ...

... building lifelong friendships

... protecting and improving access to alpine places

... sustaining and growing climbing and mountaineering achievement

... enhancing alpine safety

... building appreciation, enjoyment and protection of alpine places